



FORMORE
STORIES

sleeveless shirts, flashy shots, and broad smiles — Sinner seems almost colourless in his Nike attire: grey shorts, a navy-blue shirt, and a white baseball cap. As he strolls onto the court before matches, he appears expressionless. No headphones with music, like Frances Tiafoe. During the coin toss, no kangaroo jumps followed by serpentine sprints, like Nadal.

Understated in personality, Sinner is overwhelming in power. During his decisive 6-4, 6-4 victory over No. 5 Taylor Fritz in the final, *Tennis Channel* analyst Jim Courier remarked, "Fritz does nothing better than Sinner. I would have said, arguably, maybe his first serve is better — but not today."

Sinner, lanky and wiry-strong at slightly over 6'3", surpassed Fritz with an overall service rating of 323 to 288. He whacked more aces, 14 to 8, with no double faults; won 83 per cent of his first-serve points compared to 70 per cent for Fritz; and faced only one break point, which he saved with a wickedly wide serve in the last game of the opening set.

Imagine averaging 123 mph with 50 per cent of his first serves landing within a mere foot of the centre line or sideline. That astounding precision comes from countless practice hours and his penchant for perfectionism. His choice of the Head Graphene Touch

Speed racket followed a series of blind tests at the Monte Carlo Open in April, using several Head frames painted identically. "That's the mark of a hungry player, always looking for the [extra] edges," said Courier.

A technique change also paid off handsomely. "Sinner's serve is so much better since he switched [from a platform stance] to a step-up serve," *Tennis Channel* analyst Andy Roddick pointed out. A rocket server himself, Roddick was the last American man to win a Grand Slam singles title, 21 years ago at the US Open.

Sinner's superiority over Fritz was even more pronounced in the return stats, with a rating of 124 compared to just 55 for the American. Overall, Sinner finished with 28 winners and only nine unforced errors, compared to Fritz's 20 and 15 respectively.

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Sinner had already defeated Fritz by an identical 6-4, 6-4 score in the round-robin stage, where he also stopped a much-improved Alex de Minaur 6-3, 6-4, and Daniil Medvedev 6-3, 6-4. That was Sinner's third straight win over the declining, 28-year-old Russian and eighth in their last nine meetings. Medvedev, who has lost four

straight matches against Alcaraz, admitted that losing regularly to the new Big Two has sapped his motivation for the sport.

Other players Medvedev once dominated are also figuring out how to outsmart and overpower 'The Octopus'. During his 6-4, 6-3 loss to Fritz, the once-lovable Russian villain — remember his irritating, and later amusing, antics when winning the 2021 US Open — became downright unlovable.

Smashing his racket and a courtside microphone earned him two separate code of conduct violations, a point penalty, and jeers from the 13,000 spectators. "I get angry and frustrated," Medvedev said. "This time it was completely with myself — not with anyone else. Just with myself."

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